

Creamy Pesto Beans

These creamy pesto beans come together in just 30 minutes. The sauce clings to tender white beans, and whatever is left is perfect for sopping up with a warm, crusty baguette. For a heartier meal, serve the beans over whole-grain pasta, letting the sauce coat every bite.

By **Craig Ruff** | Updated on September 7, 2025

✓ Reviewed by Dietitian **Emily Lachtrupp, M.S., RD**

Active Time: 30 mins

Total Time: 30 mins

Servings: 4

Nutrition Profile:

No Added Sugar Gut Healthy Mediterranean Diet Sesame-Free Soy-Free High-Fiber High-Protein Egg-Free

Ingredients

- 3 tablespoons extra-virgin olive oil
- 2 medium shallots, finely chopped (about ½ cup)
- 4 medium cloves garlic, thinly sliced (about 1½ tablespoons)
- 1 teaspoon salt-free Italian seasoning
- ¼ teaspoon crushed red pepper
- ⅓ cup heavy cream
- ⅓ cup lower-sodium vegetable broth
- 2 (15-ounce) cans no-salt-added cannellini beans, rinsed
- ⅓ cup refrigerated basil pesto
- ¼ cup packed fresh basil leaves, plus more for garnish
- 1 tablespoon lemon juice
- ¾ cup grated Parmesan cheese
- 4 (1-ounce) pieces crusty whole-wheat baguette, toasted

Directions

Step 1

Heat 3 tablespoons oil in a large skillet over medium heat. Add chopped shallots and sliced garlic; cook, stirring often, until softened and translucent, about 2 minutes. Add 1 teaspoon Italian seasoning and ¼ teaspoon crushed red pepper; cook and stir until the spices are toasted and fragrant, about 1 minute.

Step 2

Stir in $\frac{1}{3}$ cup cream and $\frac{1}{3}$ cup broth; bring to a simmer over medium-high heat. Stir in rinsed beans and return to a simmer. Simmer, stirring occasionally, until the beans are warmed through and the sauce is thick enough that a spoon leaves a trail when dragged through it, 3 to 4 minutes.

Step 3

Remove from heat and stir in $\frac{1}{3}$ cup pesto, $\frac{1}{4}$ cup basil and 1 tablespoon lemon juice. Let cool slightly for 3 minutes, then gradually stir in $\frac{3}{4}$ cup Parmesan until melted. Garnish with additional basil, if desired. Serve with toasted baguette.

Frequently Asked Questions

What's the difference between heavy cream vs. heavy whipping cream?

They are the same product, used as a dessert topping, coffee creamer or added to soups and sauces to make them creamier. The name just varies based on the manufacturer.

How should I store and reheat leftovers?

This recipe is best served the day you make it. However, you can store it in an airtight container in the refrigerator for up to 4 days. Reheat it in the microwave, and add a little broth if it's too thick.

What should I serve with Creamy Pesto Beans?

We would pair this recipe with a salad like our Basic Green Salad with Vinaigrette for a well-rounded meal.

I am trying to cut down on saturated fat. Can I use replace the heavy cream with something else?

Yes, swapping out the heavy cream for half and half, whole milk or even a plant-based milk like soy or almond milk will help reduce the saturated fat. Because heavy cream is thicker than these alternatives, you can expect the texture to be looser.

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Nutrition Facts

Per serving: **Serving Size $\frac{3}{4}$ cup beans & 1 oz. baguette** 601 calories; total fat 31g; saturated fat 10g; cholesterol 38mg; sodium 605mg; total carbohydrate 59g; dietary fiber 12g; total sugars 4g; added

sugars 0g; protein 24g; vitamin c 3mg; calcium 399mg; iron 6mg; potassium 1083mg

Additional reporting by Sarah Pflugrad, Ph.D., RDN, CSCS *and* Linda Frahm

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